

REBELLION

A Trick-Taking Card Game for Two to Seven Players, Inspired by *Blake's 7*

Version 2.49

THE SETTING

In this setting, humanity lives under a single galaxy-spanning government: the Terran Federation. It presents itself as civilization's protector, but it is not altruistic — in practice, it's an empire that controls and dominates every world under its reach, holding power through surveillance, conditioning, and force where persuasion fails. Its authority runs through Supreme Commander Servalan, ruthless and ambitious, backed by enforcers like Travis and the full weight of Space Command.

Scattered resistance movements push back wherever they can find a foothold. The most famous gathers around a man named Blake — a small, mismatched crew of escaped prisoners and reluctant allies that history affectionately remembers as Blake's 7.

Somewhere on the edge of Federation space, crews scramble for survival. Every card played is a choice: rescue your people, dodge the Federation's notice, and pray nobody triggers the destruction of Star One before you're ready for it.

If you're new to the show: Star One is the Federation's central communications and control nexus — the single installation that holds its entire administration together. Its location is one of the best-kept secrets in the galaxy; not even the Federation's own command structure knows exactly where it is. That secrecy is exactly why the Reserve matters here. As long as nobody's dealt with it, Star One stays buried, which works in the rebellion's favor — but it also means nobody's actually defending it. Its location only becomes critical the moment something far worse than the Federation comes looking.

PLAYERS & EQUIPMENT

- **Players:** Two to seven. See *The Deal*, below, for sizing.
 - **Equipment:** One standard 52-card deck **plus one Joker** (53 cards total — see *The Wild Card*, below). Pencil and paper for scoring.
 - **Deal:** Clockwise. Rotates one seat to the left after each Mission (hand).
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THE FACTIONS (Suit Meanings)

Suit	Faction	In Play
♥ Hearts	The Crew of the Liberator	Good — capture these for points
♦ Diamonds	Technology	Useful — small points plus a one-time power
♣ Clubs	Hazards	Bad — small penalties plus complications
♠ Spades	Federation Forces	Very bad — avoid capturing these

THE WILD CARD — VILA RESTAL

The Joker represents **Vila**, a Delta grade thief who plays by his own rules.

- **Points:** +10 if captured.
- **Wild play:** Vila may be played to any trick at any time, even when you could have followed the suit led. He never has to follow suit himself.
- **He wins any trick he enters.** Vila played to a trick beats every other card regardless of suit led — the best thief in the system walks out with the lot.
- **When Vila leads a trick,** there is no natural suit — so the player who played him declares which suit must be followed for that trick. Vila holds the cards when he's in control of a situation.

Because Vila can be played to any trick and wins it outright, he's one of the most powerful cards in the deck — use him to steal a trick loaded with Hearts, or to deny someone else a winning hand at a critical moment. He's still a coward, but he's a very effective one.

CARD VALUES & SPECIAL POWERS

All seven of the Liberator's original crew are accounted for somewhere in the cards: Blake, Avon, Jenna, Cally, and Gan in Hearts, Vila as the Joker, and Zen as the King of Diamonds.

Aces rank high in every suit for the purpose of winning a trick. Point values are as follows:

♥ Hearts — The Crew (capture for points)

Card	Points	Notes
2-9	Face value (+2 to +9)	Soolin, Del Tarrant, Veron and all the other rebels that fight alongside Blake are in these cards.
10 — Gan	+10	
J — Cally	+10	If played in the same trick as Avon (A♥), triggers The Full Crew — see <i>Star One: Reserve Powers</i> , below.
Q — Jenna Stannis	+10	If played in the same trick as Avon (A♥), triggers The Full Crew — see <i>Star One: Reserve Powers</i> , below.
K — Blake	+10	If played in the same trick as Avon (A♥), triggers The Full Crew — see <i>Star One: Reserve Powers</i> , below.
A — Avon	+10	If Avon and any other Hearts face card (Cally, Jenna, or Blake) are both played in the same trick , triggers The Full Crew — see <i>Star One: Reserve Powers</i> , below. Compulsion: if Anna Grant (10♠) is played in the same trick, Avon must be played immediately as the next card into that trick, regardless of suit led. The effect only lasts for that trick.

♠ Spades — Federation Forces (avoid capturing)

Card	Points	Notes
2-9	Face value (−2 to −9)	Every Federation magistrate, commander, and extra who had it in for Blake are in these cards.
10 — Anna Grant	−10	A tearful reunion? Or inevitable betrayal? Either way, beautifully played. During the trick she is played in: any player holding Avon (A♥) must play him immediately as their next card into this trick, regardless of suit led. Once the trick resolves the effect is gone — her window is brief, so timing is everything.
J — Mutoid	−10	She needs a biochemical serum to survive and draws it through the needle in her own arm. At scoring , she devours one Heart card of your choice from

Card	Points	Notes
		your own Capture Pile — its points don't count this Mission, no matter what. This is mandatory if you hold any Hearts. If your Capture Pile has no Hearts in it, she cannot get her serum — she stops working and scores 0 herself this Mission.
Q — Section Leader	−10	No special effect. He has no agenda, no powers, and no particular grudge against anyone. He is simply delighted to be here, and when the shooting starts, he smiles just a little too widely.
K — Travis	−10	Forces you to seize the Reserve. See <i>Star One: Reserve Powers</i> , below. <i>"I'm done with humanity, and I'm done with the Federation — since they're both done with me."</i>
A — Servalan	−10	Whoever captures this card must immediately lay their hand face-up on the table for the rest of the Mission. They still play normally — but everyone can now see and plan around their cards.

♦ Diamonds — Technology (small reward, plus a power)

Card	Points	Notes
2-9	+1 each	Many extra devices, blasters, explosives, tricks and strategies are in these cards.
10 — IMIPAK	+5	At scoring , if another 10 card (Gan, Dayna Mellanby, or Anna Grant) is also sitting in your Capture Pile, you may assassinate one card of your choice from any player's Capture Pile, including your own — it and its points are cancelled. Entirely optional. IMIPAK targets people, not hardware: the target must be a Hearts card, a Spades card, the 10 of Clubs (Dayna Mellanby), or the Joker (Vila). It cannot be used on Diamonds or other Clubs cards, and cannot target itself.
J — Teleport Bracelet	+5	On capture: the Aquitar cell can only transport living matter — swap one people card from your Capture Pile back into your hand. Valid targets are any Hearts card, any Spades card, Vila (the Joker), or Dayna Mellanby (10♣). Technology, hazards, and other non-living cards cannot be teleported.
Q — <i>Liberator</i>	+5	On capture: you may Destroy Star One — see <i>Star One: Reserve Powers</i> , below. Additionally, if the Andromedan Invasion is currently underway when you capture this card, you may cancel it — the Andromedan stands down, the remaining Reserve cards stay where they are, and you lead the next trick . Play and scoring continue normally. Finally, if the Liberator and the Ace of

Card	Points	Notes
		Clubs (Star One) are both captured in the same trick , the Ace of Clubs's Mission-ending effect is cancelled — the Liberator intercepts the detonation. The Mission continues, and the Ace of Clubs scores normally as –5 in whoever's Capture Pile it lands in. At scoring: if the Liberator, Zen (K♦), and the Asteroid Field (Q♣) are all in your Capture Pile, the Asteroid Field is negated — it scores 0 this Mission.
K — Zen	+5	At scoring: if Zen, the <i>Liberator</i> (Q♦), and the Asteroid Field (Q♣) are all in your Capture Pile, the Asteroid Field is negated — it scores 0 this Mission. The Liberator knows these rocks, but only if you're the one flying her.
A — Orac	+5	On capture: look through the hand of any one opponent (information only — take nothing). At scoring: you may cancel the point value of one person card of your choice from any player's Capture Pile — the cancelled card scores 0 this Mission. Valid targets are any Hearts card, any Spades card, Dayna Mellanby (10♣), or Vila (the Joker). Orac doesn't assassinate — he simply wins an argument that nobody in the galaxy can defeat. Entirely optional, usable once per Mission.

♣ Clubs — Hazards (small penalty)

Card	Points	Notes
2-9	–1 each	Many hazards the crew faced are in these cards.
10 — Dayna Mellanby	0/+10	The lone bright spot in this suit — but she only scores if the Star One battle actually happened this Mission. At scoring, her +10 only counts if at least one of the following occurred during play: the Ace of Clubs (Star One) was captured by anyone, the Full Crew triggered, Travis seized the Reserve, or the Andromedan Invasion began. If none of those happened, she scores 0. She trusts a good blade or a charge of plastic explosive more than she trusts most Federation tech, which is why she's filed here among the Hazards — but she doesn't arrive until after the battle.
J — System Failure	–5	Is it a systems failure — or a failure of the System?
Q — Asteroid Field	–5	<i>"Raise the firewall. Energy reserves diminishing rapidly."</i>

Card	Points	Notes
K — Carnell, the Psycho-Strategist	–5	Paired with Servalan (Ace of Spades), triggers The Psycho-Strategist's Gambit — see <i>Scoring</i> , below.
A — Star One	–5	Capturing this card ends the Mission immediately — unless the Queen of Diamonds (<i>Liberator</i>) is captured in the same trick, in which case the detonation is intercepted and the Mission continues. See "Ending a Mission Early" below.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

Score the most points over a number of Missions equal to the number of players (so the deal comes back around to everyone once). Highest cumulative total wins and is named **Hero of the Revolution**.

CHOOSING THE FIRST DEALER

This is a dystopian society — the burden falls on whoever drew the worst luck. Shuffle the deck and have every player draw one card, then return it to the deck and reshuffle before the real deal. Compare what you drew against the Card Values table above: whoever drew the lowest value — the most negative card at the table — deals the first Mission. Tied for lowest? Just those players draw again.

THE DEAL

The 53-card deck (52 + Vila) doesn't divide evenly among most player counts, so a handful of cards always get set aside as the Reserve to make the rest come out even.

Shuffle thoroughly, then deal clockwise, one card at a time starting to the dealer's left, until every player has the correct number of cards for your group size. Once all players have been dealt their full hand, set aside the remaining cards face-down in the centre of the table as the Reserve.

The Reserve must be kept face-down and hidden from all players throughout the Mission. Place the cards in the order they were dealt and do not disturb that order — the sequence matters, as the Andromedan Invasion leads Reserve cards one at a time from the top of the pile.

Quick reference:

Players	Cards per player	Reserve cards
2	25	3
3	16	5
4	12	5
5	10	3
6	8	5
7	7	4

THE PLAY

- The player to the dealer's left leads any card to the first trick.
- Each player, in turn, **must follow the suit led if able**. If unable to follow suit, a player may play any card from their hand — this is the moment to "sluff" a dangerous Spade or Club onto someone else's trick. Exceptions:
 - **Vila (the Joker)** may be played to any trick at any time, regardless of suit led.
 - **Anna Grant's compulsion:** if Anna Grant (10♠) is played in the current trick and you are holding Avon (A♥), you must play Avon as your very next card into that same trick, regardless of suit led. The compulsion only lasts for the duration of that trick — once it resolves, Anna's effect is gone.
- **Highest card of the suit led wins the trick** — unless Vila (the Joker) has been played, in which case Vila wins automatically regardless of what else was played.
- **Important:** the winner of a trick captures **all cards played to it**, not just their own — including any Spades or Clubs an opponent dumped into it, and including any Diamond or Joker powers, which trigger for whoever wins the trick, regardless of who actually played the card. Additionally, if the King of Spades (Travis) is among the cards captured, the trick winner must also immediately take all remaining cards from the Reserve into their Capture Pile — for good or bad, no choice in the matter.
- **The winner of a trick always leads the next one.** No card or power changes this — except the Andromedan Invasion, which can take the lead away from everyone. See below.
- The trick winner gathers the cards face-down into their **Capture Pile**.

- Play continues until every hand is empty, or until the Ace of Clubs is captured — whichever comes first.
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ENDING A MISSION EARLY: STAR ONE

If the Ace of Clubs is captured, the Federation has located Star One, and the Mission ends at once. Stop play immediately. Score the Mission using only what's already in each player's Capture Pile — cards still in hand score nothing for anyone, good or bad.

Exception: if the Queen of Diamonds (*Liberator*) is captured in the same trick as the Ace of Clubs, the Mission-ending effect is cancelled. The Liberator intercepts the detonation. The Mission continues normally, and the Ace of Clubs scores as -5 in the trick winner's Capture Pile.

This makes the Ace of Clubs a genuine double-edged card: capturing it late, while sitting on a strong pile, locks in your lead. Being forced to capture it early, before you've built a pile, can be ruinous.

STAR ONE: RESERVE POWERS

The Reserve isn't just removed from play — it's a prize, sitting on the table for the entire Mission until someone claims it, locks it away, or is forced to take it whether they want it or not. Four cards interact with it directly:

1. The Full Crew — Avon (Ace of Hearts) + any Hearts face card, played in the same trick (trick-triggered, optional). The instant Avon and at least one Hearts face card (Jack, Queen, or King — Cally, Jenna, or Blake) are played into the same trick, whoever wins that trick may immediately turn the Reserve face-up and take **any or all** of its cards into their Capture Pile, scoring their points along with everything else captured. **All Reserve cards must be revealed face-up to all players before the winner makes their selection** — the choice must be transparent. Any cards left behind are set aside face-down and out of the Mission for good. This triggers only once per Mission, the first moment the condition is met — the trick winner decides instantly.

Note that Gan (the 10 of Hearts) does **not** count as a face card for this purpose. (*Spoilers: he doesn't make it to Star One.*)

2. Queen of Diamonds — Destroy Star One (capture-triggered, optional). The instant you capture this card, you may choose to destroy the Reserve outright. Its cards are set aside, locked, and removed from the Mission — unscored, and unreachable by any other power (including the Full Crew, above) for the rest of the Mission. Decide immediately upon capture; once destroyed, it's gone for good.

3. King of Spades (Travis) — Seizes It (capture-triggered, mandatory). The instant you capture this card, if the Reserve still has cards in it and hasn't been destroyed, you **must** take all of them into your Capture Pile and score their points exactly as printed — good or bad, no choice in the matter. Travis doesn't ask permission. **All seized Reserve cards must be revealed face-up to all players as they are taken** — nobody gets to hide what Travis dragged in.

Resolution order: These trigger in whatever order their cards are actually captured during play — there's no fixed sequence. If the Reserve has already been partly or fully claimed, or destroyed, by the time a later trigger comes up, only whatever's left (if anything) is affected. An empty or destroyed Reserve has nothing left to give, take, or lock away.

Travis versus the Full Crew — order of play decides. If Travis and the Full Crew both trigger in the same trick (Avon, a Hearts face card, and Travis all played together), the order in which those cards were physically played into the trick determines who gets priority:

- **If Avon and the Hearts face card were played before Travis:** the Full Crew fires first — the trick winner may cherry-pick which Reserve cards they want, leaving the rest. Travis then seizes whatever remains, mandatory as always. The winner gets the best of it; Travis gets the scraps.
- **If Travis was played before the Full Crew completed:** Travis fires first, seizing everything in the Reserve immediately. When the Full Crew then triggers, there is nothing left to claim — Travis has already taken it all.

Stack your cards in play order and review the sequence. It matters.

A NOTE ON TRAVIS AND THE INVASION

Travis seizes the Reserve the moment he is captured — unconditionally, and regardless of whether the Andromedan Invasion has started. The two are related, but independent.

If Travis is captured **before** the Invasion begins, he empties the Reserve entirely. With nothing left in it, the Invasion trigger condition can never be met, and the Andromedans never arrive. Travis, inadvertently or not, kills the Invasion before it starts.

If Travis is captured **after** the Invasion has already begun, the same rule applies — whoever captures him must immediately take whatever Reserve cards the Andromedan hasn't led yet. Strip the Reserve bare mid-invasion and the Andromedan has nothing left to lead. The invasion ends on the spot, and the player who captured Travis leads the next trick.

Either way, Travis always grabs the Reserve. The Invasion's status only determines what "the Reserve" consists of at that moment.

THE ANDROMEDAN INVASION

Whatever's coming through the gap you left open, it didn't knock.

The Reserve doesn't have to be dealt with all at once — but the less of it gets dealt with, the closer the invasion creeps.

The trigger: After every trick during normal play, compare two numbers — how many cards are left in each player's hand, and how many cards are still sitting unclaimed in the Reserve right now. The moment those two numbers match, and the Reserve isn't empty, the Andromedans arrive. If the Reserve ever reaches 0 cards first — fully claimed by the Full Crew, seized by Travis, or destroyed by the Queen of Diamonds — **the Andromedans never come**, and the rest of the Mission plays out completely normally.

Example: In a five-player game with a starting Reserve of 3, if nothing has touched it, the invasion begins the moment every hand is down to 3 cards — giving it exactly 3 waves, enough to fill out the rest of the Mission. If the Full Crew had already claimed 2 of those 3 cards earlier in play, only 1 card would remain, and the invasion wouldn't begin until hands were down to 1 — a single, final wave.

Once triggered, the Andromedan leads every remaining trick of the Mission. Turn its next unclaimed Reserve card face-up — that's its lead, and it sets the required suit. Real players respond exactly as in a normal trick, following suit if able or sluffing if not, using the cards still in their hand. Highest card of the suit led, Andromedan included, wins the trick as usual, and the winner captures everything played to it, scored normally.

- **If a real player wins, that wave is repelled**, and the Andromedan leads its next card for the following trick.
- **If the Andromedan wins any wave, the invasion succeeds.** The Mission ends immediately and **nobody scores any points for it**. Move straight to the next Mission.
- **If the Andromedan leads Vila (the Joker) — Vila's Galactic Bluff.** Vila, ever the opportunist, has apparently convinced the Andromedans they've attacked entirely the wrong galaxy. The invasion is cancelled immediately. The Mission also ends — nobody scores, nobody wins, nobody quite knows what just happened. Place Vila face-up on the table as a monument to his achievement and move straight to the next Mission. He doesn't need a trick. He just needed five minutes alone with their fleet commander. He arrives back drinking something green and says you can all thank me later.

The invasion can be broken from the inside — by the same three cards that already interact with the Reserve, plus one more:

- **Capturing the Ace of Clubs** ends the Mission immediately, even mid-invasion, exactly as it does at any other point in the game. Scoring proceeds normally for

whatever's already in everyone's Capture Pile — a different outcome from the Andromedan winning a wave.

- **Capturing Travis (King of Spades)** forces the seizure of whatever's left of the Reserve — and mid-invasion, "what's left" means whatever the Andromedan hasn't led yet. Take it, and the Andromedan has nothing left to lead. The invasion is over, and **the player who captured Travis leads the next trick** — play and scoring continue normally from there.
- **Completing the Full Crew** — if Avon (A♥) and any Hearts face card are played into the same wave, whoever wins that wave may claim any or all of the Reserve instantly. Only claiming **all** of what's left ends the invasion; leave even one card behind and the Andromedan leads it next wave as usual. Clear it out entirely and **you lead the next trick**.
- **Capturing the Queen of Diamonds (the Liberator)** lets you cancel the invasion outright — the Andromedan stands down, the remaining Reserve cards stay where they are, and **you lead the next trick**. The Reserve remains in play for the rest of the Mission; it has not been claimed or destroyed, just left behind. This is the only way to end the invasion without touching the Reserve cards themselves.
- **If the Andromedan leads Star One (Ace of Clubs):** Star One is the Ace of its suit and cannot be beaten by any Club — left alone, the Andromedan wins that wave and nobody scores. However, several cards can intervene, and their effects resolve **in the order they were played into the trick**. Stack cards face-up as they are played so the sequence can be reviewed. In order of priority:
 - **Vila (the Joker)**, if played into the wave, wins the trick immediately — he wins any trick he enters. Whoever played Vila captures Star One, the Mission ends, and everyone scores what's in their Capture Pile normally.
 - **The Liberator (Q♦)**, if played into the wave, cancels Star One's detonation — the Mission-ending effect is intercepted. The wave resolves normally, and whoever wins it captures both cards.
 - **The Full Crew**, if triggered during the wave (Avon and a Hearts face card both played into this trick), allows the trick winner to claim any or all Reserve cards — potentially stripping the Andromedan of future leads and ending the invasion.
 - **If none of the above apply**, the Andromedan wins the wave with the unbeatable Ace of Clubs. The Mission ends immediately and nobody scores.

Order of play is always the resolution sequence. Whenever multiple effects could fire in the same trick, they resolve in the order the cards were physically played. Stack each card face-up in sequence as it hits the table — this is not just flavour, it is the official record of the trick and determines which effect fires first if there is a conflict.

If every Reserve card is led and beaten without the Andromedan ever winning, the invasion is fully repelled, and the Mission proceeds straight to scoring.

SCORING

If the Mission ended because the Andromedan won an invasion wave, there's nothing to score — skip straight to the next Mission. Otherwise, score the Mission by working through these steps, in order:

Step 1 — Orac. If a player's Capture Pile contains the Ace of Diamonds (Orac), that player may cancel the point value of one person card of their choice from **any player's** Capture Pile — the cancelled card scores 0 in this Mission. Valid targets are any Hearts card, any Spades card, Dayna Mellanby (10♣), or Vila (the Joker). Orac doesn't assassinate — he simply wins an argument nobody in the galaxy can defeat. Entirely optional, usable once per Mission.

Step 2 — Zen & the Liberator. If Zen (K♦), the Liberator (Q♦), and the Asteroid Field (Q♣) are all in the same player's Capture Pile, the Asteroid Field is negated — it scores 0 this Mission. All three must be held by the same player.

Step 3 — Gauda Prime. Look at each player's Capture Pile. If any player's pile is non-empty and contains nothing but numbered cards ranked 2 through 10 — and every single one of those cards is a prime number (2, 3, 5, or 7) — Gauda Prime happens. The instant it triggers, every Heart card sitting in any Capture Pile at the table, including the triggering player's own, is cancelled: none of them score this Mission. The cards stay exactly where they are; only the points are gone. If more than one player happens to qualify at once, it makes no difference — the effect only needs to happen once.

Step 4 — The Mutoid Needs Serum. A Mutoid's body no longer runs on anything as simple as food — she needs a biochemical serum, a blood substitute, just to keep functioning, and draws it through the needle built into her own arm. If the Jack of Spades (Mutoid) is in a player's Capture Pile, that player must choose one Heart card from their own pile for her to drain — it scores 0 this Mission, no matter what. This is mandatory if they hold any Hearts. If their Capture Pile has no Hearts in it (including any already wiped by Gauda Prime, above), she cannot get her serum — she stops working and scores 0 herself this Mission instead of her usual -10. **The Mutoid may feed on a Heart card already cancelled by Orac** — it is still physically present in the pile and she doesn't discriminate. The card remains at 0 and the Mutoid scores her -10 normally. This means holding both Orac and the Mutoid gives you a choice: cancel a weak Heart and feed it to her, protecting your stronger Hearts from being devoured.

Step 5 — IMIPAK. If IMIPAK (10 of Diamonds) and at least one other 10 (Gan, Dayna Mellanby, or Anna Grant) are both in a player's Capture Pile, that player may choose to assassinate one card of their choice from **any player's** Capture Pile, including their own — it scores 0 this Mission. The target must be a Hearts card, a Spades card, the 10 of Clubs (Dayna Mellanby), or the Joker (Vila) — IMIPAK targets people, not hardware, and cannot

be turned on Diamonds, other Clubs cards, or itself. This is entirely optional. If more than one player has the combo active, resolve each player's choice in turn, starting with whoever is seated to the dealer's left.

Step 6 — Dayna Mellanby. If Dayna Mellanby (10♣) is in any player's Capture Pile, check whether the Star One battle occurred this Mission. Her +10 only counts if at least one of the following happened during play: the Ace of Clubs (Star One) was captured by anyone, the Full Crew triggered, Travis seized the Reserve, or the Andromedan Invasion began. If none of those occurred, Dayna scores 0 regardless of who holds her.

Step 7 — Totals. Each player adds up the point values of every card remaining in their Capture Pile. Any card cancelled by Orac, negated by Zen & the Liberator, devoured by the Mutoid, assassinated by IMIPAK, wiped by Gauda Prime, or ruled out by Dayna's condition scores 0.

Step 8 — The Psycho-Strategist's Gambit. If both the King of Clubs (Carnell) and the Ace of Spades (Servalan) are in the same player's Capture Pile, that player's entire Mission total is flipped — positive becomes negative, negative becomes positive, same magnitude either way. (A total of exactly 0 has nothing to flip.) This is not optional, and the player holding both cards has no say in it once it applies.

Record the running total for each player.

Play one Mission per player, so the dealer's seat has gone all the way around the table once, then total all scores. **Highest total wins.**

Tie-breaker: play one additional Mission, "The Final Run" — sudden death, highest single-Mission score wins outright.

THE RANGE OF A MISSION

Rebellion is not a game of gentle, predictable scoring. A single Mission can swing wildly depending on how the cards fall and which combos fire, and it's worth understanding why before you sit down to play.

Typical range. In an ordinary Mission, most players will finish somewhere between roughly **-30 and +40 points**, with a strong leading score usually landing around **+15 to +25**. This is the range you should expect on a normal night of play, where the special combos either don't trigger or only partially fire.

Theoretical extremes. The deck's outer bounds are far wider than any realistic game will reach, but they're worth knowing:

- A player who somehow captured every Heart, every Diamond, Vila, and a triggered Dayna while avoiding all Spades and Clubs entirely could theoretically approach **+140**

points or more before any cancellations.

- A player stuck with every Spade and every Club, especially with Carnell and Servalan both working against them, could fall as low as **-110 to -120**.

In practice, with two or more opponents fighting over every trick, nobody is likely to come anywhere close to either extreme — but the deck is built wide on purpose, so that a Mission can feel genuinely consequential.

Why the swings are so large. Three mechanics are responsible for most of the volatility:

- **The Psycho-Strategist's Gambit** (Carnell + Servalan) flips a player's entire Mission total — positive to negative, or negative to positive. A player sitting on a strong +50 can be reduced to -50 in a single instant at scoring, and a player buried at -60 can just as easily flip into a commanding +60. This single combo is the biggest source of dramatic reversal in the game.
- **The Andromedan Invasion** can end a Mission with nobody scoring at all if the Andromedan wins a wave — instantly zeroing out what might have been an excellent Mission for everyone at the table.
- **Star One (the Ace of Clubs)** can end a Mission abruptly the moment it's captured, freezing every player's score wherever it happens to sit — which can reward a player who built up an early lead, or punish someone who was one trick away from a big haul.

Because of these three mechanics, no lead is ever fully safe until the Mission actually ends. Play accordingly.

A WORKED EXAMPLE OF A TRICK

Four players: Vargas, Ensor, Coser, and Zeeona, seated clockwise in that order, with Vargas about to lead.

- **Vargas leads the 9♥.** Worth +9 if captured.
- **Ensor** follows with the **A♥ (Avon, +10)** — currently winning.
- **Coser**, unable to follow Hearts, sluffs the **K♠ (Travis, -10)** — a calculated risk, hoping someone else wins.
- **Zeeona**, also out of Hearts, sluffs the **A♦ (Orac, +5, with power)**.

Ensor's Ace of Hearts is the highest Heart played, so **Ensor wins the trick** and captures all four cards: 9♥, A♥, K♠, and A♦.

Travis fires immediately. Because Travis (K♠) is among the captured cards, Ensor must also take all remaining Reserve cards into their Capture Pile on the spot — for good or bad,

no choice. Whatever was sitting face-down in the centre of the table is now Ensor's problem.

Ensor's net from this trick: $+9 (9♥) + 10 (A♥) - 10 (K♠) + 5 (A♦) = +14$ **points** before scoring effects, plus whatever the Reserve contributed. Later, during scoring of the whole Mission, Ensor may use Orac's power — cancelling the K♠'s -10 by winning an argument with it, turning this trick into a **+24 swing** before Reserve cards are counted. Coser's gamble to sluff Travis backfired badly; Ensor leads the next trick.

A note on the Reserve: in this example, Travis emptied the Reserve the moment Ensor captured him. During normal play — before any Travis, Full Crew, or Liberator interaction — the Reserve sits untouched in the centre of the table and trick winners don't automatically take it. However, if the Andromedan Invasion has begun, the Reserve leads every wave, and whoever wins that wave captures the Reserve card along with everything else played to the trick. That card could be anything: a high Heart worth precious points, a Federation card you'd rather not hold, or the Ace of Clubs itself — ending the Mission on the spot. For good or bad, when the Andromedans arrive, the Reserve is no longer safe.

STRATEGY NOTES

- **Don't lead into Hearts early** unless you're confident you can win the trick — handing Blake or Avon to an opponent is a gift.
- **Sluff Spades and Clubs onto tricks you're sure you'll lose**, especially early, before opponents have built piles big enough to absorb the damage comfortably.
- **The Ace of Spades (Servalan) is the single worst card in the game** — track who's still holding Spades, and never lead a Spade you can't afford to lose if you're forced to follow.
- **The Mutoid (Jack of Spades) bites back at scoring time, not during the trick.** Capturing her costs you -10 *and* one of your own Hearts at the end of the Mission — so a big pile of rescued crew isn't fully safe just because the trick is over. If you're stuck with her, you at least get to choose which Heart she takes.
- **Diamonds are quietly powerful.** Their small point values disguise how much damage their powers can do — used at the right moment, they can reshape the scoring entirely.
- **The Reserve is a battlefield of its own.** Watch for Avon and a Hearts face card landing in the same trick — they don't have to come from the same hand, and if they meet, the Full Crew fires and the Reserve is suddenly up for grabs. Consider whether the Queen of Diamonds is worth more to you destroying the Reserve than scoring it normally. If Travis (King of Spades) is still loose, remember that whoever takes him doesn't get a choice about what comes with him.

- **Watch the Ace of Clubs.** If your Capture Pile is weak, you don't want to be the one who triggers Star One. If your pile is strong, scooping it up early can end the Mission before opponents recover.
 - **The Full Crew and the Ace of Clubs are completely independent events.** Triggering the Full Crew earlier in the Mission — by landing Avon and a Hearts face card in the same trick — resolves immediately and is done. The Ace of Clubs can still appear in any subsequent trick for the rest of the Mission, and when it's captured the game ends and everyone scores what's in their pile. One does not cancel or protect against the other.
 - **Carnell and Servalan together flip your whole Mission score.** If you're already deep in the negative, deliberately chasing both can be a real comeback play — flip a bad Mission into a great one. But if you're sitting on a strong positive pile, treat both cards as radioactive: together they can undo an entire Mission's work in a single trick, and once you've got them both, there's no taking it back.
 - **Watch the gap between your hand and the Reserve.** If nobody's touched Star One by the time hands get small, the invasion is coming whether you're ready or not — and once it starts, you can't lead, you can only respond. Clearing the Reserve early, by any of the four means available, is the only way to control when (or whether) the Andromedan ever shows up.
 - **IMIPAK only works if you've already got a matching 10.** Holding it alone does nothing — you need Gan, Dayna, or Anna Grant sitting in the same pile before it's worth anything. Once it's live, it can hit anyone's Capture Pile, not just yours — save it for whoever's sitting on the biggest score at the table, not just your own worst card.
 - **Gauda Prime is rare, but it's worth knowing the shape of it.** An all-prime, all-numbered Capture Pile (only 2s, 3s, 5s, and 7s, nothing else) wipes every Heart at the table, including your own. It's not something to chase deliberately — but if you notice your pile drifting that way, think twice before sweeping in a Jack just to be safe.
 - **Dayna is the one good card hiding in a bad suit — but she comes with a condition.** Her +10 only scores if Star One was involved: the Ace of Clubs was captured, the Full Crew triggered, Travis seized the Reserve, or the Andromedan arrived. In a quiet Mission where none of that happens, she's worth nothing. In a Mission where the battle came to Star One, she's the only positive card in Clubs.
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APPENDIX: WHO'S WHO

A quick reference for anyone new to the setting, organized by suit.

The Liberator Crew (Hearts)

- **Avon (Ace)** — Kerr Avon, a brilliant, self-interested computer expert who keeps the crew alive through pragmatism more than loyalty. *First appears S1E02, "Space Fall."*
- **Blake (King)** — Roj Blake, the escaped political prisoner whose name the rebellion carries. *First appears S1E01, "The Way Back."*
- **Jenna (Queen)** — Jenna Stannis, the crew's pilot: a former smuggler with sharp instincts and sharper reflexes. *First appears S1E01, "The Way Back."*
- **Cally (Jack)** — An Auron telepathic survivor of a resistance group and demolitions expert who met up with and joined Blake and the crew on Saurian Major. *First appears S1E04, "Time Squad."*
- **Gan (10)** — Olag Gan, a gentle giant fitted with a neural limiter that prevents him from ever killing again. *First appears S1E02, "Space Fall."*
- **Vila (Joker)** — Vila Restal, a self-described coward and the best thief in the system, talked into the rebellion more than he ever volunteered for it. *First appears S1E01, "The Way Back."*

Technology (Diamonds)

- **Orac (Ace)** — A temperamental supercomputer capable of accessing nearly any data system in the galaxy, when it feels like cooperating. *First appears S1E13, "Orac."*
- **Zen (King)** — The Liberator's own onboard intelligence: cryptic, occasionally unhelpful, fiercely protective of its ship. *First appears S1E02, "Space Fall."*
- **Liberator (Queen)** — The crew's ship: alien-built, blindingly fast, and not entirely understood even by the people flying it. *First appears S1E02, "Space Fall."*
- **Teleport Bracelet (Jack)** — standard crew equipment, not a person: the device that lets the crew beam down to (and escape from) hostile worlds at a moment's notice. *First appears S1E03, "Cygnus Alpha."*
- **IMIPAK (10)** — *Induced Molecular Instability Projector and Key*. A failsafe assassination weapon: implant a trigger in a target, then detonate it from anywhere, anytime. *First appears S2E03, "Weapon."*

The Federation (Spades)

- **Servalan (Ace)** — Supreme Commander of the Federation, equally comfortable ordering a massacre or hosting a diplomatic reception. *First appears S1E06, "Seek-Locate-Destroy."*
- **Travis (King)** — A Federation Space Commander turned obsessive hunter, fixated on capturing or killing Blake at any cost. *First appears S1E06, "Seek-Locate-Destroy."*
- **Section Leader (Queen) / Federation Trooper (2-9)** — The Section Leader has no special role in the rebellion, no agenda, and no distinguishing qualities beyond his uniform. He is simply thrilled to have made it into this episode and smiles just a little

too toothily when the fighting starts. The troopers behind him are equally replaceable, and know it. *No single first appearance — they're everywhere, by design.*

- **Mutoid (Jack)** — A Federation soldier surgically and chemically altered into something closer to a weapon than a person. *First mentioned S1E06, "Seek-Locate-Destroy."*
- **Anna Grant (10)** — A name from Avon's past, eventually revealed to be something far more dangerous than it first appeared. *"I loved her. And she betrayed me. Those two facts don't cancel each other out — they just sit there, both true at once."* *First appears S3E08, "Rumours of Death."*

Hazards & Adversaries (Clubs)

- **Star One (Ace)** — see *The Setting*, above: the Federation's hidden communications nexus, and the thing this entire game keeps circling. *First named S2E13, "Star One."*
- **Carnell, the Psycho-Strategist (King)** — Servalan's tactician, who studies people closely enough to turn their own plans back against them. *First appears S2E03, "Weapon."*
- **Asteroid Field (Queen)** — *"Raise the firewall. Energy reserves diminishing rapidly."* The ordinary, unglamorous dangers of deep space. *No single first appearance.*
- **System Failure (Jack)** — There are onboard systems failures, and then there is the System — the computerised culture that built the Liberator. When the System fails, it's time to leave. *The System first appears S2E01, "Redemption."*
- **Dayna Mellanby (10)** — A weapons specialist who joins the crew in the aftermath of the Star One battle, with a personal preference for blades and explosives over Federation tech — which is why her card sits in Clubs despite scoring well for whoever holds it. Appropriately, she only scores at all if Star One was involved in the Mission. *First appears S3E01, "Aftermath."*

Key Locations

- **Gauda Prime** — a remote frontier world, and the site of the rebellion's final, bloody reckoning. *First appears S4E13, "Blake."*

Beyond the Federation

- **The Andromedan** — an alien intelligence from beyond the galaxy's edge, with no interest whatsoever in the Federation's wars — only in what's left once they're finished fighting them. *First appears S2E13, "Star One."*

"You may not have noticed, but the Federation has a long memory."